

■ By Amitabh Srivastava

He's known as much for his Karl Marx beard as his sobriquet. The water warrior from Gaya, 97 km south of Patna, is the resident agony uncle, with people flocking to him for advice on life and work. The post-graduate in sociology who has refused a number of teaching jobs only to become a "rarely paid" freelance

journalist is an unlikely hero.

Though Prabhat Shandilya has scripted a unique success story called Magadh Jal Jamaat—a loosely knit body of progressive individuals, who have so far revived more than a dozen abandoned water sources, created a few new ones, and most importantly infused in the residents of several parched villages of Gaya the need to conserve water—he remains unwilling to step into the spotlight. But he is proud that he has made it without any help from the government, with local volunteers pitching in with "shramdaan" (donating manual labour). Those who could not do that provided food for them.

It all began in the year 2006 when the Jamaat, led by him and convener Ravindra Pathak, discovered they urgently needed to arrest the downslide of the water table in Gaya, located on the banks of the river Falgu, a tributary of the river Ganga. "The signs of an impending water crisis were ominous. A 600-ft deep boring at a former MLA's house failed to yield water. It was time to pull up the socks," Shandilya recalls. And the reason for the crisis was not difficult to discern. Encroachment, siltation, government apathy and deep boring by several people, including him, had led to water scarcity in the township.

The solution, however, was not instant. "Those who could afford did not stop opting for deep boring despite our arguments. I personally stopped using my hand pump, but it had no exemplary value. Then we decided to recharge the abandoned water

sources in the district," Shandilya says.

But it was easier said than done. Initially only a handful of people, most wary and with little hope of scripting a success story, assembled to support the initiative. A couple of representations later, a seemingly unenthusiastic administration reluctantly made available shovels, spades and other digging tools. The task at hand was to desilt the Saryu Taalab, the oldest and completely abandoned source of water recharge in Gaya that had almost become a public lavatory.

The work started on May 1, 2006. It was a battle hard fought, and but for the human spirit, it would have been difficult to win. Support poured in from all quarters, prisoners of Gaya Central Jail, the Army Service Corps and CRPF personnel based in the area, besides volunteers from many political and apolitical organisations of the district. "Our efforts clearly reminded others of their social responsibility at a time when the town was facing a water crisis that had triggered migration in select pockets," says Shandilya. It took them 15 days but their efforts paid off and by May 16, 2006, the reservoir was back in shape.

This was not the end. There was still a lot of unfinished business. The volunteers then decided to repeat their success story with another seven such reservoirs. By this time many people from other parts of the district too had decided to join the initiative. Later in 2006, the 8-km-long water channel from Maanpur to Nanouk village was desilted. This move brought water to 32 tanks of the

tanking UP

★ Prabhat Shandilya, 56

Project Magadh Jal Jamaat, a loosely knit body of progressive individuals, which has so far revived several water bodies

Can-do Icon The human spirit, which can triumph over all arduous tasks

India has **4 per cent** of the world's fresh water sources and 17 per cent of the world population

